

On the emergence of impersonal *se* in Romance

This paper offers an account of the diachronic emergence of impersonal *se* (Imp_{se}) from passive *se* (Pass_{se}) in Romance as grammaticalization up the tree. Imp_{se}, with a non-agreeing DP, is in (1a), and Pass_{se}, with an agreeing DP is in (1b), both from European Portuguese (EP).

- (1) a. Vende-se estas casas.
sell.3sg.-se these houses
"They are selling these houses."
b. Vendem-se estas casas.
sell.3pl.-se these houses
"They are selling these houses."

Concretely, we claim that *se*, as a Voice head in Pass_{se} (see MacDonald 2017, MacDonald & Maddox 2018), is reanalyzed as a T head in Imp_{se} (see Belletti 1982, Cinque 1988 for Imp_{se} as Infl). Moreover, we claim that this occurred at a time when *se* had a [D]-feature, building on the analysis in MacDonald & Maddox (2018), resulting in a T with a valued version of Holmberg’s (2005 et seq.) [uD]-feature that T bears in consistent null subject languages (CNLs). We thus link the emergence of Imp_{se} to being a CNL, a positive result as we show.

Assumptions for Imp_{se} vs. Pass_{se}: In the spirit of Belletti (1982), Otero (1986), Cinque (1988), and Mendikoetxea (20008), we take *se* in Imp_{se} to be the spell-out of T with a valued version of [uD] à la Holmberg (2005, 2010), a property of T present in CNLs, but not in non-CNLs. On Holmberg’s account, the [uD]-feature must be valued by an A-topic, following Frascarelli (2007), in which case the null external argument of a verb in 3rd sg. will be referential, unless there is some special morphology on the verb, like Imp_{se}. Although Holmberg does not offer any formal mechanisms to explain how Imp_{se} removes the referential interpretation of the null external argument, we propose that *se* in Imp_{se} spells out T with a valued [D] feature. Consequently, no A-topic can value [D] in T, since it is already valued; this precludes a referential interpretation of the null subject (cf. Sigurðsson 2011).

With respect to Pass_{se}, we assume that *se* spells out Voice (MacDonald 2017, MacDonald & Maddox 2018), which minimally lacks accusative case, resulting in the theme argument controlling verbal agreement and surfacing in nominative as illustrated in (2a), which contrasts with Imp_{se} in (2b), from Italian (D'Alessandro 2004:59). (See also 1 above).

- (2) a. In Italia essi /*li* si mangiano [Pass_{se}]
in Italy they.Nom.3pl/*them*.Acc.3pl si eat.3pl
"In Italy, people eat them."
- b. In Italia **essi* /*li* si mangia [Imp_{se}]
in Italy **they*.Nom.3pl/*them*.Acc.3pl si eat.3sg
"In Italy, people eat them."

Since *se* is within the verb phrase in Pass_{se}, it can affect the argument structure properties of the predicate, while in Imp_{se}, *se* is outside the verb phrase (in T), and does not affect the argument structure properties of the predicate. Consider Romanian, argued to lack Imp_{se} (Dobrovie-Sorin 1992), where only an agreeing DP is grammatical, patterning with Pass_{se}, as in (3a). Moreover, in contrast to Spanish, Italian and EP, *se* cannot appear in copula or analytical passive constructions, in (3b) and (3c) respectively in Romanian.

- (3) a. Se construiesc/*construiește locuințe noi
SE.3 built.3pl / built.3sg. houses.nom new.nom.pl
"New houses are built."
b. *Adesea se este trădat de prieteni falși. c. *Nu se este niciodată mulțumit.
frequently, se is betrayed by friends false not se is never satisfied
"One is frequently betrayed by false friends." "One is never satisfied."

Reanalysis of [D] in T: Our main claim is that *se* was reanalyzed as the higher head T as “grammaticalization up the tree”. Independent clitic movement moved *se* into the T domain, and then *se* was reanalyzed as a T head, as illustrated in (4).

- (4) a. $[_{TP} T [_{voiceP} pro \textbf{Voice}_{se[D]} [_{VP} V]]] \rightarrow$ b. $[_{TP} \textbf{T}_{se[D]} [_{voiceP} pro \textbf{Voice} [_{VP} V]]]$

Furthermore, we claim that *se* was reanalyzed as T at a time when it bore a valued [D] feature, thus, resulting in a non-referential interpretation of the external argument in Imp_{se}

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constructions, as discussed above. This proposal makes sense on MacDonald & Maddox's (2018) account of the loss of *by*-phrases in *Pass_{se}* in Romance. These authors claim that there are two stages in this process: stage 1 in (5a), followed by stage 2 in (5b).

(5) a. [VoiceP *pro* Voice_{se}[D] ...] b. [VoiceP *pro*[D] Voice_{se} ...]

Couched within a cyclic approach to language change (van Gelderen 2004, 2011) they explain the change in terms of *pro* in Spec,Voice *renewing* the properties of *se* as they are lost as part of its reanalysis as a Voice head. Adopting assumptions by Legate (2014) (and Longobardi 2004), they claim that at stage 1, *pro* in Spec,Voice lacks [D], and thus does not saturate the external argument slot. In contrast, in (5b), since *pro* bears a [D] feature, it does. Moreover, assuming Bruening's (2013) analysis in which a *by*-phrase in passive saturates the external argument slot, it follows that at stage 1 a *by*-phrase can appear in *Pass_{se}*, while it cannot at stage 2. We claim that *Imp_{se}* was reanalyzed at a time when *se* bore a [D] feature. This generates the expectation that *Imp_{se}* developed when *by*-phrases were allowed in *Pass_{se}*. This seems to be the case. Regarding EP, Naro (1976) observes *by*-phrases with *Pass_{se}* from +/-1300-1614, and Naro (1963) notes the emergence of *se* with non-agreeing DPs at +/-1550. Regarding Spanish, *by*-phrases can be found from 1205-1550 (Monge 1954, MacDonald & Maddox 2018) and non-agreeing forms as early as 1200s (Kärde 1943). Regarding Italian, *by*-phrases (with specific agents) are abundant from 1250-1450, and start decreasing from 1450-1600 (Sansò 2011), while non-agreeing DPs emerge near the end of the 13th century (Giacalone Ramat & Sansò 2011:203–206). We illustrate from Spanish one example of a *by*-phrase with *Pass_{se}* in (6a) and one example of a non-agreeing DP with *se* in (6b), both from the 13th century.

- (6) a. ...e non se defendiere por él...
 ...and not *Pass_{se}* defend by him...
 '... and that he not be defended by him...'
 b. E, si se cree los magicos, expellan las tempestades...
 and if *Imp-se* believes.3S the magicians expel.3P the storms
 "And, if one believes the magicians, they (the magicians) expel storms."

Importantly, reanalysis takes place when the input is ambiguous or obscure (Kroch 1989, Santorini 1989, Pintzuk 1991, Roberts & Roussou 2003). Sentences like those in (7), with both the theme DP and the verb in singular are present in the earliest texts, and are ambiguous between *Pass_{se}* and *Imp_{se}*, since the DP could be an agreeing subject of *Pass_{se}* or a non-agreeing direct object in *Imp_{se}*.

- (7) Se vendió la casa. "They sold the house."/"The house was sold."
se sell.3sg the house

Conditions on the emergence of *Imp_{se}*: Our analysis links the development of *Imp_{se}* directly to a property of CNLs, which is a positive result. As far as we are aware, only CNLs have developed *Imp_{se}* constructions. Spanish, Italian and EP have *Imp_{se}*, but not French. Brazilian Portuguese is losing both the CNL property and *se* constructions (see Kato 1999, Nunes 1991 a.o.). On the grammaticalization up the tree analysis proposed here, at the time *se* was reanalyzed as T, both *se* and T bore the same type of feature, which further motivates reanalysis. Given this situation and the claim regarding the timing of the development of *Imp_{se}*, we can generate necessary conditions for the development of *Imp_{se}*: i) be a CNL; and ii) allow *by*-phrases in *Pass_{se}*. Note that Romanian is such a language. It is a CNL and as illustrated in (8) *Pass_{se}* allows *by*-phrases, data from Geniušienė (1987:267).

- (8) Vesela se spală de el. "Dishes are washed by him."
 dishes *Pass_{se}* wash by him

On this account the conditions are ripe for the development of *Imp_{se}* in Romanian, yet it has not happened, as discussed above. We will show how one difference between Romanian and other Romance languages, a result of Slavic influence, can explain the delay: Case on *se* – Romanian shows case distinctions on reflexive clitics, while Romance does not.

Selected reference: MacDonald, J.E. & M. L. Maddox. 2018. *J. of Linguistics* 54:389-427